

Babylonian and Assyrian art

The city of Babylon lay south of present-day Baghdad. During the Old Babylonian Kingdom (c.1894–1595 BCE) King Hammurapi (1792–50 BCE) defeated the other southern states and unified the former kingdoms of Sumer and Akkad. Sculpture predominated during this period. The New Babylonian Kingdom (627–539 BCE) achieved particular greatness in the reign of Nebuchadnezzar II (605–562 BCE). He rebuilt Babylon, surrounded it with massive walls and, c.575 BCE, built the huge Ishtar Gate, adorned with colourful reliefs of symbolic beasts, including bulls, lions and snake-dragons.

The Assyrians of northern Mesopotamia ruled c.2500–605 BCE, and were at their peak in the Neo-Assyrian period (883–612 BCE) when huge carvings of mythological Lamassu, or winged guardians, were installed in the palace of King Ashurnasirpal II (883–859 BCE) at Nimrud. They constructed lavish palaces and temples in different capitals, including Nimrud, Ninevah and Khorsabad, and filled them with monumental statues and reliefs, often glorifying the king, depicting battle scenes, grand banquets and people bearing gifts.



Lamassu figure from Khorsabad, c.710 BCE